WEEK 03 / HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS

Home Consoles, PC Gaming, and the Rise of Genres

Exploration of early consoles and the growth of PC gaming and shareware.

This week, we explore the development of early gaming consoles and the rise of PC gaming, including the impact of shareware distribution on the gaming industry. We will also discuss the emergence of various game genres and how they shaped player experiences.

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39 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Consoles, Computers, and Distribution

REQUIRED

The Evolution Of Gaming PC's

YOUTUBE | 11 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uhFcxcoP5rE&ab_channel=TheGamer

This video explores how improvements in computer hardware transformed video games over time. It talks about topics like:
- early 3D games,
- graphics cards,
- hardware acceleration,
- and the evolution of gaming performance.

It also briefly references the television series Halt and Catch Fire, which I included in the optional resources. It's a fictional drama inspired by the early computer industry of the 1980s and is absolutely worth watching if you enjoy technology history.

The video also touches on:
- Doom,
- early NVIDIA graphics cards,
- and the rising cost of gaming hardware over time.

On a personal note, one thing I especially enjoyed was seeing hardware that looked almost identical to what my family had growing up with our Commodore 64.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

REQUIRED

Evolution of Video Game Graphics (1947-2023)

YOUTUBE | 19 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RNvYGcgoGcs&ab_channel=Flatlife

Next is a video on the evolution of video game graphics from 1947 through 2023.

This one showcases how graphics technology advanced over time across both consoles and PCs.

You'll see everything from:
- early experimental visuals,
- to iconic arcade and console graphics,
- all the way up to modern games like Hogwarts Legacy and the newest Microsoft Flight Simulator.

The video also includes footage from virtual events inside Fortnite, including concerts and live experiences, which are interesting examples of how games have evolved into social platforms rather than just entertainment products.

A couple terms I want to quickly clarify:

RGB

RGB stands for Red, Green, and Blue - the primary light colors used to generate images on digital displays.

Vector Graphics

Vector graphics are images created mathematically using lines, curves, and shapes rather than individual pixels.
This differs from raster graphics, which are built pixel-by-pixel.

Vector graphics scale smoothly without losing quality, while raster graphics are better suited for detailed photographic imagery.

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REQUIRED

The Birth of Video Games

ARTICLE | 8 MIN

https://www.classicarcademuseum.org/the-birth-of-video-games

This article discusses the Magnavox Odyssey - one of the earliest home gaming consoles.

What makes this especially interesting for us here in New England is that the article was written by the vice president of the American Classic Arcade Museum in New Hampshire, and it highlights connections to Nashua, New Hampshire and early gaming history.

It's a quick read, but it's a fun reminder that some important gaming history happened fairly close to home.

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REQUIRED

Colossal Cave - A Deeper Look

YOUTUBE | 8 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VJhxVTvyxIA

Next is a short video about Colossal Cave Adventure.

This is extremely important historically because it was one of the first widely-played text adventure games and helped inspire entire genres of games that followed.

The video is narrated by legendary game designer Roberta Williams, co-founder of Sierra On-Line.

She explains how this game inspired:
- graphical adventure games,
- interactive fiction,
- and eventually titles like King's Quest.

The original game ran on a mainframe computer and was played through teletype terminals over phone lines.

Players literally typed commands and received printed text responses.

It's difficult to overstate how influential this game became.

The video also discusses how Colossal Cave Adventure became:
- one of the first viral video games,
- and arguably one of the first pirated video games.

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REQUIRED

The Internet History Podcast: The History of Sierra Online With Laine Nooney

PODCAST | 73 MIN

https://www.internethistorypodcast.com/2016/06/the-history-of-sierra-online-with-laine-nooney/

The podcast interview with Laine Nooney focuses heavily on Sierra On-Line.

It explores:
- the founding of Sierra,
- the rise of graphical adventure games,
- and how the company helped shape the role of the modern game designer.

One especially important point: Roberta Williams was not primarily a programmer. Instead, she focused on storytelling and game design while programmers built the tools that allowed her ideas to become playable games. That separation between programmer, artist, writer, and designer became foundational to modern game development.

The podcast also discusses:
- Leisure Suit Larry,
- marketing controversies,
- and the software industry crash that followed the Atari collapse.

As noted, the podcast's site features some images and a summary.

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REQUIRED

The Evolution of Game Genres: NES, Gameboy, and SNES

ARTICLE | 11 MIN

https://www.fortressofdoors.com/the-evolution-of-game-genres-early-nintendo-consoles/

The article on Nintendo game genres examines how Nintendo categorized and marketed games across the NES, Game Boy, and SNES eras.

One interesting takeaway is that early game genres were often less formally defined than we think of them today.

Nintendo helped standardize many genre labels that are still used:
- action,
- adventure,
- sports,
- RPG,
- puzzle,
- simulation,
- and more.

The article also reinforces Nintendo's role in helping revive the home console market after the Atari crash.

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REQUIRED

Massive two-year project recovers 144 previously undumped Sega Genesis game ROMs from the mid-1990s

ARTICLE | 10 MIN

https://www.tomshardware.com/video-games/retro-gaming/massive-two-year-project-recovers-144-previously-undumped-sega-genesis-game-roms-from-the-mid-1990s-lost-garfield-and-flintstones-games-among-the-notable-finds

Next we have a short article with a long video - feel free to watch all or part of the 60-minute YouTube video if you want, but the article is shorter and provides some highlights.

The Video Game History Foundation recently completed a two-year mission to save a massive collection of digital media from the Sega Channel, a pioneering 1990s cable-based subscription service.

By analyzing old backup tapes from former employees, researchers successfully recovered 144 previously lost game ROMs and a rare prototype for a 16-bit web browser. Notable discoveries include exclusive versions of Garfield and a movie-based Flintstones title that historians once feared were gone forever.

This effort highlights the importance of digital preservation for early online services that predated modern platforms like Steam. The project ensures that unique Sega Genesis content, including specialized demos and regional exclusives, remains accessible for future generations.
These findings offer a rare glimpse into the experimental era of digital distribution and early console connectivity.

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REQUIRED

The Joy of Sticks

ARTICLE | 35 MIN

https://romchip.org/index.php/romchip-journal/article/view/204

The article The Joy of Sticks is a more academic reading focused on joystick history and the Atari joystick connector standard.

This was the connector used across many early gaming systems and personal computers, including the Commodore 64.

For me personally, this article is deeply nostalgic because these are the exact kinds of controllers I grew up using.
Even though the topic sounds narrow, it's really about standardization, hardware ecosystems, and the growth of home computing culture.

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REQUIRED

Atari: Game Over

YOUTUBE | 66 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=03oC6-zPZHQ

One of the biggest pieces this week is the documentary Atari: Game Over.

This documentary focuses on:
- the infamous E.T. video game,
- the 1983 video game crash,
- and the urban legend surrounding buried Atari cartridges in the desert.

A few key takeaways:

The E.T. Game Was Made in Five Weeks

That timeline is astonishing.

Even for the early 1980s, similar games normally took several months to produce.

Howard Scott Warshaw - the game's designer - completed the project under extreme pressure.

The documentary makes a strong argument that the real problem wasn't the developer, but the unrealistic business decisions surrounding the project.

The Burial Was Real

Yes - Atari really did bury cartridges in a landfill.

But it turns out it wasn't just E.T. cartridges. Many other Atari materials were buried as well.

The documentary follows archaeologists and historians who tracked down the site and excavated it.

The Crash Was Bigger Than One Game

The E.T. game did not single-handedly destroy the industry.

Instead, it became a symbol of larger problems:
- rushed production,
- poor quality control,
- oversaturation,
- and unrealistic expectations.

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LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

REQUIRED

Shareware: When Copying Disks was actually Promoted

YOUTUBE | 4 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_SX8SpQj004

This short video is about shareware, a revolutionary marketing tool with repercussions that are still impacting us today.

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REQUIRED

How four friends invented (modern) FPS games | An idSoftware Documentary Doom, Quake & Wolfenstein

YOUTUBE | 74 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WIuCOsB4nHs

A documentary on id Software that covers:
- Wolfenstein 3D,
- DOOM,

- Quake,
- and the technological innovations behind them.

Some important concepts introduced here include:

Raycasting

A rendering optimization technique that allowed games to only draw what the player could actually see.

This dramatically improved performance in early 3D games.

Modding

id Software openly encouraged players to modify their games.

They even released tools that allowed players to build their own levels.

This helped popularize gaming mod communities that still exist today.

Shareware Distribution

Instead of relying entirely on retail stores, id distributed portions of games freely and encouraged players to share them.

This became an incredibly successful grassroots marketing strategy.

Multiplayer and Online Gaming

The documentary also discusses:
- deathmatch multiplayer,
- early internet gaming,
- and technological advances like client-side prediction, which are still foundational to online games today.

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REQUIRED

The History of Myst: How It Changed Video Games Forever & Defined a Genre

YOUTUBE | 12 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dhwFqH7IBEU

This video explores how the 1993 game Myst revolutionized the industry by moving away from fast-paced action toward cerebral exploration and environmental storytelling. Developed by Cyan Inc., the game was a technological breakthrough that popularized the CD-ROM format and used pre-rendered 3D graphics to create an immersive, visually rich world that standard hardware of the time could not otherwise render in real-time. Myst became a cultural phenomenon and one of the best-selling PC games of the decade, defining the puzzle-adventure genre and influencing how video games are perceived as an art form.

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REQUIRED

The 10 Most Important Game Engines of ALL TIME

YOUTUBE | 20 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zvftgKI8tXA

A game engine is used to build and operate video games. Instead of programming everything from scratch, developers use an engine to handle heavy-lifting tasks like graphics rendering, physics simulations, audio processing, artificial intelligence, and memory management. This video ranks the most consequential game engines based on their community size and the volume of games produced. I include this primarily to introduce you to the concept and variety of game engines as well as names of specific engines since these will come up from time to time as we discuss video games.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Game Over: How Nintendo Conquered the World

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Game-Over-Nintendo-Conquered-World/dp/0679736220

"A chronicle of Nintendo's climb to the top of the video game market describes the company's tactics and how it has become one of the most successful high tech companies in the world."

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Hackers: Heroes of the Computer Revolution

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/2sp9f6/alma991045345259708681

"Traces the exploits of the computer revolution's original hackers -- those brilliant and eccentric nerds from the late 1950s through the early '80s who took risks, bent the rules, and pushed the world in a radical new direction. With updated material from noteworthy hackers such as Bill Gates, Mark Zuckerberg, Richard Stallman, and Steve Wozniak, Hackers is a fascinating story that begins in early computer research labs and leads to the first home computers."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Not All Fairy Tales Have Happy Endings: The rise and fall of Sierra On-Line

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Fairy-Tales-Happy-Endings-Line-ebook/dp/B08KG2XLMR

"Sierra On-Line was one of the very first computer game companies and at one time dominated the industry. The author, Ken Williams, founded Sierra On-Line Sierra with his wife Roberta who went on to create many of the company's best selling games. Sierra grew from just Ken and Roberta to over one thousand employees

and a fan base that still exists today, despite the fact that the company was torn apart by criminal activities, scandal and corruption that resulted in jail sentences and the collapse of Sierra. This is the behind-the-scenes story of the rise and fall, as it could only be told by the ultimate insider."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Apple II Age: How the Computer Became Personal

BOOK

https://www.lainenooney.com/the-apple-ii-age.html

"An engrossing origin story for the personal computer-showing how the Apple II's software helped a machine transcend from hobbyists' plaything to essential home appliance."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Perfect Game Tetris: From Russia With Love

BOOK

https://www.diangelopublications.com/shop/p/the-perfect-game

"Discover the riveting journey of Henk B. Rogers, a visionary entrepreneur who transformed Tetris from a humble Soviet puzzle game into an international sensation. From programming his first hit game in Japan, to defying geopolitical boundaries in the Soviet Union, Rogers' relentless pursuit of innovation led to the creation of the Tetris Company and cemented his place in gaming history. Follow his thrilling story of high-stakes negotiations, unyielding determination, and a passion for sustainable energy that reshaped his life beyond video games."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Right, Down + Circle: Tony Hawk's Pro Skater (Pop Classics Book 12)

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Right-Down-Circle-Skater-Classics-ebook/dp/B0C7HLJXBB

"Going from a hobby toy for surfers to an Olympic sport, skateboarding has had a tumultuous history. Today, professional skateboarders land endorsement deals with Nike and Adidas, while popular television series like HBO's Betty tell the stories of diverse crews of skaters living in New York City. So how did a fledgling subculture rise from its near-death knell in the '90s to become ubiquitous today? It was simply a matter of finding the right messenger. In 1999, the bestselling video game Tony Hawk's Pro Skater was released, and a new generation was exposed to skateboarding culture right in their very own homes. Kids and adults alike could now spend hours playing as actual skateboarders, learning the vernacular, listening to the music skateboarders loved, and having fun onscreen before trying to skate IRL in the driveway. Right, Down + Circle explores how a video game starring the most famous pro skater in the world brought skateboarding culture - and its ever-shifting markers of music, subversion, and coolness - to the masses and ultimately transformed the culture it borrowed from in the process."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Save Point: Reporting from a video game industry in transition, 2003-2011

BOOK

https://doi.org/10.1184/R1/15157572

"Nearly 50 years after the launch of Pong created the video game industry as we know it, it's fair to say the medium is approaching maturity in its middle age. Culturally, commercially, artistically, and technologically video games have never been more relevant, vibrant, or widely recognized as a major pastime and a unique form of expression. Getting to that point, though, meant video games had to go through their own awkward adolescence. This book covers some of the changes that rocked the game industry between 2003 and 2011. That time was a sometimes-uncomfortable transition period, where the industry did its best to grow up with the young audience that had grown up with games as their entertainment of choice through the '70s, '80s, and '90s. Many gaming trends that are still apparent today found their roots in this period, when technological, cultural, and business forces pushed the industry to change faster than ever before. The pieces collected in this book analyze how games were learning from their past and influencing the future, report on some of gaming's growing and myriad sub-communities, and examine how the business of selling and marketing games was evolving alongside the explosive growth of the Internet."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Tetris

APPLE TV+ MOVIE

https://tv.apple.com/us/movie/tetris/umc.cmc.4evmgcam356pzgxs2l7a18d7b?action=play

"Based on the true story of American video game salesman Henk Rogers (Taron Egerton) and his discovery of Tetris in 1988. When he sets out to bring the game to the world, he enters a dangerous web of lies and corruption behind the Iron Curtain."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Halt and Catch Fire

AMC+ SERIES

https://www.amcplus.com/shows/halt-and-catch-fire--1002226

"Navigating the thin line between visionary and fraud, genius and delusion, an unlikely trio takes great risks in a race to build a computer that will change the world as they know it in this critically-acclaimed drama."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Console Wars

PARAMOUNT+ DOCUMENTARY

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gHpfLnQW8y8&ab_channel=ParamountPlus

"A look back to 1990 when Sega, then a fledgling arcade company, assembled a team of underdogs to take on the greatest video game company in the world, Nintendo."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Mythic Quest

APPLE TV+ SERIES

https://www.ubisoft.com/en-us/entertainment/film-tv/mythic-quest

"A workplace comedy that follows a team of video game developers as they navigate the challenges of running a popular video game."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Surf Ninjas

MOVIE

https://tubitv.com/movies/100021246/surf-ninjas

"Two surfer dudes discover they are princes of a small South Pacific island and are destined to save their native land from a cruel despot."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The creators of Tetris didn't know about this...

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=u9RYzx2me0E

In this interview, entrepreneur Henk Rogers discusses his pivotal role in the global success of Tetris and his legendary dealings with high-level Nintendo executives. He clarifies the historical record regarding the game's licensing journey from Soviet Russia to the Game Boy, while revealing personal anecdotes about his enduring friendship with the game's creator, Alexey Pajitnov. The conversation highlights Rogers' career as a series of strategic business "power-ups" and showcases a rare version of the game that provides new insight into its early production. Ultimately, the dialogue connects Rogers' past as a video game pioneer to his current mission with the Blue Planet Alliance, where he applies his tenacious problem-solving skills to advocate for 100% renewable energy mandates worldwide.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Tetris: From Russia with Love

TV DOCUMENTARY ON YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6ohCy4ktA5w

Created by Alexey Pajitnov at a Soviet scientific institute in 1985, Tetris began as a simple digital translation of a favorite puzzle that quickly became an addictive phenomenon across the Eastern Bloc. Because the Soviet system did not recognize intellectual property rights, the game's global expansion triggered a high-stakes legal battle between Western capitalists and the Soviet state agency ELORG. Negotiators like Henk Rogers and Robert Stein navigated a complex landscape of Iron Curtain bureaucracy and corporate espionage to secure lucrative rights for emerging platforms like the Nintendo Game Boy. While the game generated millions for international corporations and became a cornerstone of gaming history, its inventor initially received no financial reward due to the restrictive political landscape of his home country.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

How Prince of Persia Defeated Apple II's Memory Limitations

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sw0VfmXKq54&ab_channel=ArsTechnica

In this historical retrospective, game designer Jordan Mechner recounts the grueling creative process behind the 1989 classic Prince of Persia, focusing on how severe hardware limitations forced him to innovate. Operating within the Apple II's meager 48K memory constraint, Mechner utilized a complex rotoscoping technique to achieve lifelike movement, manually tracing film frames of his brother and Errol Flynn to translate human weight into pixels. The narrative highlights the birth of the Shadow Man, an iconic antagonist created not by initial design, but through a clever programming workaround to add excitement without consuming additional memory for new assets. Ultimately, Mechner illustrates how creative friction and technical barriers can refine a project's vision, proving that the most memorable gameplay mechanics often emerge from the necessity of fighting through constraints.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

History of PC Gaming

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PEukRq5_c_8&ab_channel=NVIDIA

This video traces the historical trajectory of personal computer gaming from its humble origins as a university research project in the 1960s to its current status as a multi-billion dollar global industry. The evolution began with foundational hardware like the Commodore 64 and transitioned through the rise of 3D graphics and the invention of the GPU, which drastically increased the scale and fidelity of virtual environments. The text highlights how the medium shifted from isolated arcade-style experiences to massive online simulations and competitive sports, fundamentally changing how communities interact through digital social spaces. Ultimately, the source frames the PC as a continually evolving platform defined by its unpredictability, moving toward a future of total immersion through virtual reality and user-generated content.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Beyond Solitaire Podcast 184: Laine Nooney on the Apple II Age

PODCAST

https://beyondsolitaire.buzzsprout.com/1091807/episodes/16627148-episode-184-laine-nooney-on-the-apple-ii-age

In this podcast interview, game historian Laine Nooney discusses their book, The Apple II Age, which explores how the emergence of the consumer software market was driven by the specific hardware and cultural positioning of the Apple II computer. Nooney argues that the era between 1977 and 1984 was a pivotal period of industrialization for personal computing, during which the "home computer" identity was forged through diverse software categories like education, business, and games. Nooney emphasizes the importance of archival evidence and the experiences of everyday workers over the mythologized "genius" narratives of industry founders. Furthermore, Nooney advocates for the preservation of digital history through their open-access journal, ROM chip, highlighting the necessity of saving material ephemera and oral histories from all levels of a company's hierarchy to truly understand economic and cultural power in technology.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Let's Begin Again: Sierra On-Line and the Origins of the Graphical Adventure Game

ARTICLE

https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1166784.pdf

Laine Nooney's scholarly article reexamines the origins of Sierra On-Line by challenging the traditional, linear "evolutionary narrative" that dominates video game history. The text argues that the company's first hit, Mystery House, is often oversimplified as a mere technical stepping stone or a rival to text-based fiction, rather than being understood through its material and domestic realities. By detailing the collaborative dynamic between Roberta and Ken Williams, the author highlights how Roberta's visual design process and Ken's technical ingenuity converged to pioneer the graphical adventure genre. Ultimately, Nooney utilizes a counter-historical methodology to show that Sierra's emergence was not an inevitable march of progress, but a complex result of specific technological conditions and human affect within their California home.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Ultimate History of Video Games

BOOK SERIES

https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/series/UHV/ultimate-history-of-video-games/

Steven L. Kent's acclaimed literary series documents the evolution of the electronic entertainment industry. There are two primary volumes: the first focuses on the early era of arcades and the birth of iconic franchises, while the second explores the high-stakes corporate battles of the twenty-first century between giants like Sony, Microsoft, and Nintendo.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Classic Postmortem: The Making Of Myst

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7cULHgP8tmo

In this retrospective presentation, Robin Miller details the serendipitous creation of Myst, a landmark title that prioritized nonlinear storytelling and explorable environments over traditional gaming conventions. Developed on a modest budget using HyperCard, the project was born from a desire to create an immersive world for adults where the player acts as the true protagonist without the distance of an avatar. The brothers navigated significant technical limitations of early CD-ROM technology by using pre-rendered 3D graphics and "ages" to manage memory, while their design philosophy focused on non-arbitrary puzzles that felt like natural parts of the environment. Ultimately, Miller attributes the game's massive success to a pure creative process fueled by personal curiosity and rigorous observational play-testing, rather than market projections or established industry trends.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

How Myst Almost Couldn't Run on CD-ROM | War Stories | Ars Technica

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EWX5B6cD4_4

In this retrospective, co-creator Rand Miller explores how Cyan transitioned from simple interactive books to the groundbreaking 3D world of Myst by embracing the severe technical constraints of early computing. The narrative traces the evolution of their design philosophy from the "magic" of text-based games to the realization that environmental storytelling and high-stakes problem-solving could create a sense of realism. To overcome the hardware limitations of the era-specifically the sluggish seek times of single-speed CD-ROM drives-the team meticulously organized data and utilized distributed rendering across multiple computers to manifest their vision. Ultimately, Miller reflects on the game's unexpected commercial success and how that legacy of "indie" innovation survives today through crowdfunded projects like Firmament, which continue to prioritize creative risk-taking.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.
LO 5: Students will gain insights into how technologies like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and online connectivity shape gaming experiences.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Cyan and Myst - Series Memories with Rand Miller / MY LIFE IN GAMING

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Zx1a1boLQxU

This video retrospective documents the history and creative philosophy of Cyan, the pioneering studio led by Rand Miller that revolutionized the adventure game genre. It explores how Myst became a cultural phenomenon by prioritizing atmospheric exploration and integrated environmental puzzles over traditional gaming tropes like combat or player death. By tracing the series through its technologically ambitious sequel Riven and its transition into fully polygonal environments, the video illustrates a consistent focus on transporting players to believable, alien worlds. Ultimately, the source serves to bridge the studio's influential

past with its modern ambitions, highlighting how their newest project, Obduction, aims to recapture the original sense of mystery using contemporary game engines.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The First Text Adventure Game Ever Is Finally Open Source

ARTICLE

https://www.vice.com/en/article/the-first-text-adventure-game-ever-is-finally-open-source/

The article details the historical preservation of Colossal Cave Adventure, widely recognized as the first text-based adventure game, which has now been released as open-source software. Originally created in 1976 by Will Crowther, the game's code was recently uploaded to GitLab by Eric S. Raymond to allow the global developer community to modernize and refine this pivotal piece of hacker history. By making the source code public, the project ensures that a title which once influenced the foundational elements of gaming-such as puzzles and fantasy exploration-remains functional on contemporary computers rather than existing solely as a static museum artifact.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Rick Adams' Colossal Cave Adventure page

WEB SITE

https://rickadams.org/adventure/

This webpage serves as a comprehensive digital archive and portal dedicated to Colossal Cave Adventure, the seminal interactive fiction game that pioneered text-based gaming in the 1970s. Through a collection of historical anecdotes, quotes from its creators, and links to playable versions, the site frames the game as a cultural milestone as essential to its genre as Shakespeare is to literature. It explores the game’s unique dual nature, detailing how it functioned as both a realistic simulation of an actual Kentucky cave and a fantastical realm filled with magic, elves, and cryptic puzzles. By providing maps, forums, and technical downloads, the site acts as a central hub for enthusiasts to study the history and enduring legacy of this virtual underground odyssey.

Yes, you can even play the game on the Web!

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Entire History of RPGs

YOUTUBE | 164 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8o3i10OuMFQ

Although this video is very long, the first 12 minutes provides a definition of Role-Playing Games, that might be helpful. This comprehensive history explores the evolution and identity of Role-Playing Games, tracing their development from the tabletop systems of Dungeons and Dragons to modern digital blockbusters. It highlights how the genre’s DNA is defined by the fusion of individual character expression and statistical rule systems, distinguishing true RPGs from other games that merely feature roles or choices. By examining the shifting landscape between Western and Japanese development, the video details how technological leaps like 3D graphics and CD-ROMs simultaneously fueled innovation and led to the downfall of legendary studios like Interplay and Origin Systems. Finally, the source emphasizes the genre’s cyclical nature, noting how the rise of

crowdfunded indie titles has recently restored the deep, narrative-driven complexity that was once sacrificed for mainstream console appeal.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Next Level with DanTDM

RADIO SHOW

https://www.classicfm.com/radio/shows-presenters/next-level-dan-tdm/

"Daniel Middleton, aka DanTDM, who is one of the biggest content creators on YouTube with more than 29 million subscribers, hosts video game music show on Classic FM. Every Saturday evening, Dan will showcase the greatest gaming music, packed into each two-hour programme. He celebrates gaming's most legendary soundtracks including The Legend of Zelda, Final Fantasy VII, Street Fighter II and one of his favourite games, Minecraft."

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